also said it was a case of downright betrayal of the promise made to them at the sub-committee meeting on 3 November. He also said that Longowal had asked it to be conveyed to Swaran that in the light of this development it would not be possible for them to postpone or withdraw their Dharam Yudh Morcha.

Swaran Singh then called Pranab Mukherjee to check the veracity of the information he had received from the Akalis. Confirming it, Pranab Mukherjee wanted Singh to suggest ways and means of retrieving the situation. Swaran Singh told Mukherjee that he had tried his best to save Punjab from the deepening crisis, but in view of the overnight change in the earlier approved statement he would not like to be associated with the negotiations in future

I am reproducing here the text of the statement actually made by Home Minister P.C. Sethi in the Lok Sabha on 4 November. [16]

> Government has been deeply distressed over the situation in Punjab. The Prime Minister and senior members of the cabinet have met delegation of the Akalis several times. The Prime Minister has indicated to them that practically all religious demands could be accepted subject to details being worked out but this could not be finalized because of their other demands.
>
> During the recent agitation, Government made further efforts to resolve the crisis and has been considering the demands conveyed recently by the 5-members committee of Akali leaders through Sardar Swaran Singh. Certain areas of agreement have been identified in respect to some demands. The others concern various states also. Therefore, consultations have to be held with Punjab and other concerned Governments and also with representatives of other communities before a decision can be taken. This process of consultations has been initiated and I have been in touch with the respective Chief Ministers and others including, leaders of opposition parties and Members of Parliament. It is likely that this process will take some more time.